

CSP529 Technical Writing & Publishing W26

Practical 3

From Reading to Evidence: What Am I Really Saying?

Theme:

Before asking "How do I cite this?", ask "What exactly am I saying, and why should the reader believe it?"

Why This Practical?

Technical writing is not merely the presentation of technically sounding information. A technical writer continuously makes decisions about whether a statement is a fact, definition, observation, claim, interpretation, or assumption.

These distinctions determine whether evidence is required and what kind of evidence is appropriate. This practical therefore begins **before citation**.

Learning Outcomes

After completing this practical, students should be able to:

- read a professional technical article analytically rather than passively;
- identify its principal message and supporting ideas;
- summarize technical material accurately in their own words;
- distinguish among different kinds of technical statements;
- recognize statements requiring supporting evidence;
- distinguish what an author reports from what an author interprets;
- recognize when wording is stronger than the available evidence;
- prepare the analysis professionally using LaTeX.

Stage 1 — Read Before You Write

Each group will be assigned **one article**.

A. Read the complete article.

Do **not** begin writing immediately.

While reading, identify:

- What problem/topic is being addressed?
- Why is it important?
- What is the principal message of the author(s)?
- What evidence/information is presented?
- What conclusions or interpretations are made?
- What remains uncertain?

AI tools are not to be used for reading or summarizing the article at this stage.

Stage 2 — Summarize

B. Write a summary of the article in your own words.

Maximum: 400 words.

The summary should allow a technically educated reader who has **not read the original article** to understand its essential contribution.

Do not simply shorten every paragraph of the article.

Decide:

What must remain, what can be omitted, and why?

After completing the summary, give it a suitable title of your own.

Stage 3 — What Kind of Statements Did We Make?

Now examine **your own summary sentence by sentence**.

Classify each sentence using the following categories:

Code	Type	Meaning
F	Established Fact	A generally established/verifiable technical or factual statement
D	Definition	States what a term/concept means
C	Claim	An assertion requiring consideration/support
O	Observation	Something reported, measured, noticed or obtained

I	Inference / Interpretation	Meaning or conclusion derived from information/evidence
A	Assumption / Prediction	Something assumed or projected beyond what is directly established

C. Prepare the following table in LaTeX:

No.	Sentence	Classification	Evidence Required?	Why?
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Do not classify mechanically.

If a sentence could reasonably belong to more than one category, select the category you consider most appropriate and **justify your decision**.

Stage 4 — The Evidence Question

For every sentence ask:

How do I know this?

Then determine:

D. Does this statement require supporting evidence?

If Yes:

What evidence supports it?

If No:

Why can it reasonably stand without a citation in this context?

You should begin discovering here that:

Not every sentence needs a citation, but every substantive statement must be defensible.

Stage 5 — Find the Difficult Sentences

E. Identify TWO sentences from your summary that were most difficult to classify.

For each:

1. Give your classification.
2. State the alternative classification you considered.
3. Justify your final choice.

This is important.

Marks will not depend merely upon selecting the expected letter. The quality of reasoning behind the classification matters.

Stage 6 — Now Examine the Professional Author

Return to the original article.

F. Select SIX sentences from the original article.

Try to select sentences representing different categories.

Prepare another table:

Original sentence	F/ D/ C/ O/ I/A	Evidence required?	Evidence provided by author?	Your reasoning
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Now compare professional writing with your own writing.

G. Discuss:

What differences do you observe between the way the professional author makes statements and the way your group wrote its summary?

Stage 7 — Strength of a Claim

Find the **strongest claim** in your own summary.

H. Ask:

Does the evidence presented in the original article justify the strength with which we have written this sentence?

Consider the difference among words such as: may → suggests → indicates →

demonstrates → establishes/proves

Are these interchangeable?

Rewrite your sentence if necessary.

Record:

Original version → Evidence available → Revised version

Stage 8 — LaTeX Deliverable

Prepare the entire work as a properly structured LaTeX document.

Do not ask for a ready-made template.

Your document should appropriately use what you have learned in Practicals 2 and 2-

Extension, including:

- title and authors;
- sections/subsections;
- tables;
- labels and cross-references;
- citations;
- reference to the assigned article;
- appropriate formatting;
- page numbering and consistent document structure.

LaTeX correctness is expected; technical reasoning remains the driving force.

Stage 9 — AI Enters Only Now

Only **after completing Stages A–H**, you may give your 400-word summary to an AI tool.

Ask it to classify your sentences using the same F/D/C/O/I/A scheme.

I. Do NOT accept its answer.

Instead identify:

- one classification where you agree with AI;
- one where you disagree;
- one where AI's answer made you reconsider your own classification.

For the disagreement:

Defend either your classification or AI's classification using reasoning.

This is a much better use of AI than asking it to complete the assignment.

Stage 10 — Peer Review

Exchange only your final PDF with another group.

The reviewing group identifies:

1. One sentence whose classification is particularly convincing.
2. One classification they disagree with.
3. One statement needing stronger evidence.
4. One sentence whose wording appears stronger than its evidence.
5. One improvement to the summary.

The original group may either **accept or reject** each suggestion—but must state why.

This introduces you to a fundamental feature of scholarly publishing:

A reviewer recommends; an author must make and defend the final intellectual decision.

Final Individual Reflection

Every student individually completes:

QR1. Before undertaking this practical, what did you understand by a technical fact?

QR2. Which distinction among fact, definition, claim, observation, inference/interpretation, and assumption/prediction did you find most difficult to make? Why?

QR3. What do you now understand by supporting a technical statement with evidence?

QR4. Based on your learning from this practical, what would you change in the way you write technical content in the future?

Writing Logbook — Practical 3

Add the following entries:

1. What statement did we initially classify incorrectly or reconsider?

2. What caused us to reconsider it?

3. What did we learn about the relationship between a claim and evidence?

4. What did AI classify differently from us?

5. What did we learn about our own technical writing from the peer reviewer?

You first need to internalize:

Statement → Nature of statement → Need for evidence
